

Spotify India — Getting People to Listen More

Business Requirements Document (Simplified) · The engagement & listening-time problem

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This is the plain-language version of our BRD. It defines the problem we’re solving and why — **not** the solution. We’ll get to ideas and features later; first we all need to agree on the problem.

The short version

India is one of Spotify’s **biggest audiences but smallest earners**. The single most powerful lever we have is **engagement** — how much time people actually spend listening. It’s a simple chain: **more listening** → **people stick around** → **sticking around is what earns money** (ads for free users, subscriptions for premium).

Today, a lot of Indian listeners aren’t building the daily habit. Often the music doesn’t feel relevant enough (wrong language, mood, or moment), the app can feel heavy on data, or free options like YouTube already feel ‘good enough.’ So people listen a little, drift away, and don’t come back as often as they could.

This document lays that problem out clearly so design, engineering, and strategy start from the same page. (The specific numbers come from our Milestone 1 research — marked **[M1]** where they go.)

What we’re trying to achieve

- **The business goal (the why):** earn more and lose fewer users, by getting more value out of a huge audience.
- **The product goal (what we’ll actually move):** more **time spent listening** per person — more days active, longer sessions, more often.

In one line: **the product goal (listening time) is how we reach the business goal (revenue and retention)**. If we only chase installs or sign-ups, we’re measuring vanity, not value.

Who we’re solving for

India isn’t one audience — it’s many. People differ by **city vs town, free vs paid, age, and language**, and each listens differently. Three quick stand-ins:

Person	In plain words	What they really want (their ‘job’)
Aditya Gen Z, city, free	College student, metro, budget phone, limited data, likes what’s trending.	“On my commute or with friends, give me effortless, on-trend music — don’t make me search.”

Person	In plain words	What they really want (their 'job')
Meera Millennial, Tier-2, free	Working professional, smaller city, prefers her regional language, watches her data.	"While I work or do chores, play familiar regional music that just works and doesn't eat my data."
Rohan Millennial, city, premium	Busy urban professional, several devices, playlists + podcasts.	"When I focus or relax, give me reliable, spot-on listening across my devices without fiddling."

What's getting in the way

Four honest reasons people don't listen as much as they could:

- **Relevance** — the music we surface doesn't always match their language, mood, or the moment, so they lose interest or go elsewhere.
- **Access** — data cost, budget phones, and patchy internet make listening feel heavier than it should.
- **Habit** — without a relevant first experience, people don't build the daily habit, so they come back less.
- **Value** — free alternatives (especially YouTube) feel 'good enough,' so both our free and premium experiences have to clearly earn their place.

What we're NOT doing (yet)

So expectations stay clear:

- We are **defining the problem**, not designing the fix — no features, screens, or ideas yet.
- No pricing, packaging, or content-licensing changes here.
- India only, mobile-first, both free and premium users.
- Solutions come later (Milestone 4), *after* we've tested our assumptions.

What 'good' looks like

Our **North Star** — the one number that best shows we're delivering value — is **time spent listening** (minutes per active user per day). It rolls up simply:

More listening time → better retention (people stay) → more money (ad revenue + premium conversion, higher ARPU/LTV).

The handful of things we'll watch:

- **Listening time** per active user (our North Star), by segment.
- **Stickiness & sessions**: daily vs monthly actives, sessions a day, how long each lasts.
- **Retention**: how many come back after 7 and 30 days; how many churn.
- **Money signals**: ad listening hours, free→premium conversion, revenue per user.

Actual starting points and targets come from Milestone 1 [M1] — we'll set them together.

What we're assuming, and what's fixed

We're assuming: our Milestone 1 findings hold; most Indian users start on free; language relevance and affordability really matter; and listening time is a fair early signal of retention and revenue.

What's fixed (constraints): low willingness to pay, varied devices and connectivity, catalogue/licensing we can't change here, strong free competition, evolving Indian data rules, and a cross-team, multi-time-zone way of working.

Who's involved

Product (owns the framing), Design & UX Research (users, personas, journeys), Engineering (what's feasible, performance & data), Data/Analytics (the metrics and baselines), Marketing/Growth, Content & Regional teams (language relevance), and Strategy/Leadership (the business goals).

A few terms, in plain English

Term	Plain meaning
Engagement	How actively people use the app — here, mostly how much they listen.
North Star metric	The one number that best shows we're delivering value: listening time .
KPI tree	A simple map of how listening time rolls up into retention, then money.
Retention / churn	How many people keep coming back vs how many leave.
ARPU / LTV	How much money an average user brings in — per period, and over their whole time with us.
Job-to-be-Done	The real reason someone plays music — the 'job' they hire it for.

The bottom line: if we help people listen a little more — by making it more relevant, easier to access, and worth the habit — retention and revenue follow. That's the whole game. Solutions come next; agreeing on this problem comes first.